Designing Accessible Documents

1. Introduction

Accessible documents allow assistive technology to present content in the order an author intended. A tagged PDF carries a logical structure tree that describes headings, paragraphs, lists and tables independently of how the page is drawn.

1.1 Why structure matters

- Screen readers follow the tag tree, not the visual layout.
- Reflow on small screens depends on paragraph boundaries.
- Tables need header cells so data can be announced in context.

Element	Purpose	Required
H1-H6	Navigation	Yes
Figure	Alternative text	Yes

2. Remediation workflow

Automated tools can supply document metadata, tab order and a first pass at the structure tree. Judgement calls such as alternative text and reading order still need a person to confirm them before the file is published.



Figure 1. Colour blocks used as a placeholder.